and he wanted to offer himself as a national alternative. Carried away by his Delhi success, his impetuosity got the better of him. The AAP, with no national organization, suddenly announced it would contest more than 400 seats. ‘We thought this was the best time to make an impact. Even if we could get thirty to forty seats, we could become the third largest party in the country,’ a Kejriwal aide told me. The resignation was to prove a big blunder, driven as much by hubris as naivety.

Weeks later, Kejriwal would admit to me in an interview that resigning as Delhi chief minister was a ‘mistake’, but he called it a failure to communicate to the people the reasons for the resignation. Maybe he had slowly realized that politics is a game of patience. Maybe he had finally recognized the changing public mood. I certainly could sense it. We were recording an election programme in Delhi’s Chandni Chowk, and in a number of middle-class colonies, the typical response we got was, ‘*Kejriwal, arre voh toh bhagoda hai!’* (Kejriwal is a politician who runs away.)

I continue to believe that if Kejriwal had remained in office, focusing the energies of his administration into making Delhi a corruption-free city, he would have forged an administrative track record for his party and a possible ‘Delhi model of governance’ to offer to a future electorate, just as in this election Modi had so successfully held up his Gujarat model. Kejriwal’s rise, like that of Modi, had been the direct fallout of the wave of public anger against the Congress-led UPA government. India was looking for leaders who could shake up the system and challenge the ruling establishment, but do it through effective governance, not just through rhetoric.

The AAP’s abdication from governmental responsibility caused widespread disillusionment. The March election tracker we did showed a drastic fall in Kejriwal’s popularity in Delhi and beyond. The poll also showed AAP would get less than ten seats in the general elections. Narendra Modi and Amit Shah could afford to breathe easily again. It was almost as if the fall of the AAP gave a fresh momentum to the NaMo wave. But there were others, just as powerful, who were still feeling the heat.